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Senior Software Engineer

GCHQ

Apply before 11:55 am on Monday 9th November 2026



Reference number

482472

Salary

£50,354 - £60,036

A Civil Service Pension with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Job grade

Higher Executive Officer

Contract type

Permanent

Type of role

Engineering

Working pattern

Flexible working, Full-time, Part-time, Compressed hours

Number of jobs available

1

Contents

[Location](#)

[About the job](#)

[Benefits](#)

[Things you need to know](#)

[Apply and further information](#)

Location

Cheltenham, Manchester

About the job

Job summary

GCHQ is an intelligence, cyber and security agency with a mission to keep the UK safe. We use cutting-edge technology, ingenuity and partnerships to identify, analyse and disrupt threats. Working with our intelligence partners, MI5 and MI6, we protect the UK from terrorism, cyber attacks, and espionage. At GCHQ, you'll do varied and fascinating work in a supportive and inclusive environment that emphasises teamwork.

Flexible working

We recognise the importance of a healthy work-life balance and offer a range of working patterns, including full-time, part-time, and compressed hours. Hybrid working, which combines working on-site and from home, may be more limited due to the nature of the work. However, some homeworking may be available depending on business needs. We also support flexible start and finish times, where possible, to help you manage your personal and professional commitments.

Find out more about flexible working [on our website](#).

Job description

As a Senior Software Engineer, you'll play a pivotal role in solving mission-critical challenges. You'll contribute to the architecture and design of both new and existing systems, establish and promote best practices, and deliver high-quality software solutions. Drawing on your expertise in a range of software engineering methodologies, you'll introduce fresh ideas and innovative approaches that make a real impact at the core of our mission: keeping the UK safe, both in the real world and online.

This is a practical, impact-driven role with plenty of opportunities to develop yourself and others. Operating at a deep technical level, you'll apply your expertise across a variety of software engineering frameworks and technologies, working with languages such as JavaScript, Java, Node.js, Python, Rust and Go. Alongside hands-on engineering, you'll help shape how teams build and deliver software by defining code review, branching and deployment strategies, and reviewing pull requests to support high-quality, maintainable solutions.

For our Cheltenham roles, we are particularly interested in candidates with experience in technologies and practices such as C++, Golang, Python, Rust, CMake, HELM, YAML, JSON, containerisation, VCPkg, observability, DevOps, Kubernetes, systems administration and Linux. However, we also welcome applications from candidates whose experience aligns with any of the technologies and disciplines outlined above.

You'll bring a pragmatic approach to adopting new software engineering practices, using them to improve quality, productivity and delivery, and helping others do the same. As part of a wider network of peers, you'll collaborate and learn from others. With your experience, you'll set the standard, introduce innovative ways of working, and help shape technical priorities.

Whether leading and mentoring a team or acting as the technical expert within a high-performing group, you'll draw on your knowledge of diverse methodologies to deliver impactful solutions. Confidently engaging with both technical and non-technical stakeholders, you'll make a positive contribution to the wider engineering community.

Training and development

At GCHQ, we're committed to your growth and development. From the moment you join, a comprehensive induction will introduce you to our organisation, providing insight into how we operate and the collaborative environment you'll be part of. This lays the foundation for a learning journey tailored to your goals and preferred learning style.

From day one, access to mentors and subject matter experts will help you settle into the role. You can continue to have a mentor for as little or as long as you choose throughout your career. We invest in your development and adapt to the way you like to learn. Support and encouragement are provided

every step of the way, as you become an integral part of our innovative team. We'll provide the space and resources for continuous learning and improvement, with up to 30% of your time dedicated to personal development, giving you the freedom to explore new technologies, build professional skills, or pursue areas of growth that interest you.

From books, online courses, and conferences to real-world projects supported by your team, we'll provide the resources you need to grow. Learning and development opportunities tailored to your role cover a wide range of software disciplines including front-end design, site reliability engineering, data engineering, solution architecture, machine learning operations, UX, Agile, cloud engineering and security. We'll even support formal qualifications through dedicated funding and provide subscriptions to platforms like Cloud Academy, Pluralsight, and O'Reilly to help stay ahead.

Our culture embraces a growth mindset and values equality, encouraging teams and leaders to bring their best every day. Whether you're exploring advanced software engineering patterns, gaining certifications like AWS Developer or Certified Scrum Master, or developing leadership skills through internal training, we'll help you build the career you want. As your expertise grows, you'll also have opportunities for skill reviews that can lead to recognised additional skills payments, supporting both your development and progression within the organisation.

Person specification

As a Senior Software Engineer, you will bring expertise in the frameworks and technologies mentioned above, along with experience working with cloud platforms AWS, Azure, and GCP. You'll have successfully led Agile project teams, evaluated customer business requirements, and delivered high-quality software solutions that make a real impact.

Strategic and self-driven, you'll serve as a bridge between teams, communicating technical information with clarity and confidence. You'll thrive in a fast-paced, innovative environment where creativity is key to solving complex and unprecedented challenges.

Experience of generative AI would be advantageous, whether through using AI assisted software development tools, understanding agentic patterns, or developing applications that use large language models. An awareness of

how to evaluate AI-generated outputs and use these technologies responsibly, securely and effectively would also be beneficial. What matters most is your curiosity and willingness to develop your knowledge as these technologies evolve.

We welcome experienced professionals from a variety of related fields, including security engineering, site reliability engineering and data engineering. Your genuine enthusiasm for software engineering, combined with your ability to mentor others, collaborate effectively, and stay ahead of emerging technologies, makes you a valuable contributor to a forward-thinking engineering community.

We're Disability Confident

GCHQ is proud to have achieved Leader status within the Department for Work and Pensions' Disability Confident scheme. This initiative encourages employers to think differently about disability and take action to improve how they recruit, retain, and develop disabled people. As a Disability Confident Leader, we aim to ensure that a fair and proportionate number of disabled applicants who best meet the essential minimum criteria for this position, will be offered an interview, if it is practical for us to do so. This is known as the Offer of an interview.

To secure an interview for this role, you will need to meet the minimum criteria assessed during the application sift. The minimum criteria in order of application process are:

You'll be required to reach the minimum pass mark for the online Situational Judgement Test (SJT), which assesses criteria important for all roles in our organisation.

Able to demonstrate evidence of where you've taken ownership of a technical project or piece of work.

Able to demonstrate the ability to understand several modern languages/frameworks, such as Golang, Java, JavaScript, Node.js, Python, Rust.

Able to demonstrate experience working in an Agile technical project team.

Able to demonstrate the practical application of software engineering principles to deliver, maintain and improve software solutions in a complex technical environment.

Equal opportunities

At GCHQ diversity and inclusion are critical to our mission. To protect the UK, we need a truly diverse workforce that reflects the society we serve. This includes diversity in every sense of the word: people of different backgrounds, ages, ethnicities, gender identities, sexual orientations, ways of thinking, and those with disabilities or neurodivergent conditions. We therefore welcome and encourage applications from everyone, including individuals from groups that are under-represented in our workforce, such as women, people from ethnic minority backgrounds, individuals with disabilities, and those from low socio-economic backgrounds.

Find out more about our culture, working environment and diversity [on our website here](#).

Benefits

Alongside your salary of £50,354, GCHQ contributes £14,587 towards you being a member of the Civil Service Defined Benefit Pension scheme. [Find out what benefits a Civil Service Pension provides \(opens in a new window\)](#).

You will receive a starting salary of £50,354 to £60,036. This includes a basic salary, skills payment, and a concessionary payment of £2,758. The final amount will depend on your skills and experience. You will also receive a one-off recruitment bonus of £3,500, split into two payments: £1,750 on joining and £1,750 upon successful completion of your probation period. Other benefits include:

- 25 days of annual leave, automatically increasing to 30 days after 5 years' service, plus 10.5 days of public and privilege holidays

- opportunities for recognition through our employee performance scheme

- interest-free season ticket loan

- excellent pension scheme

- cycle to work scheme

- on-site facilities such as a gym, restaurant, and coffee bars (available at some locations)

paid parental and adoption leave

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our [candidate guidance \(opens in a new window\)](#) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

Our recruitment process is fair, transparent, and based on merit.

Here is a brief overview of each stage, in order:

1. An initial online application form including pre-screening questions to ensure you meet the eligibility criteria.
2. Online Situational Judgement Test (SJT) in which you rate the appropriateness of responses to a series of short scenarios.
3. Technical and competency-based interview, including a presentation.
4. If successful, you will receive a conditional offer of employment, subject to vetting.

Please note you must successfully pass each stage of the process in order to progress to the next. Your application may take around 6 to 9 months to process, including vetting, so we advise you to continue any current employment until you have received your final job offer.

Before you apply

To work at GCHQ, you must be a British citizen or hold dual British nationality. Read the full [eligibility criteria](#).

This role requires the highest level of security clearance, known as Developed Vetting (DV). It's something everyone in the UK Intelligence Community undertakes. Find out more about the [vetting process](#).

Please note we have a strict drugs policy. Once you start your application, you must not take any recreational drugs, and you'll need to declare any previous drug usage at the relevant stage.

Before applying, we recommend setting up a separate email address for your contact with us to ensure your personal and application correspondence remain separate. Try to avoid including identifying features in your email address, such as your first and/or surname and date of birth. This is good practice and will help you manage your application with us more securely.

The role is based in Cheltenham or Manchester, so you'll need to live within a commutable distance. Please consider any financial implications and practicalities before submitting your application.

We offer reasonable reimbursement of travel costs for candidates attending in person interviews or assessments during the recruitment and vetting process. Full details will be provided with your interview or assessment invitation.

Reimbursement is discretionary and will only be made in line with the Candidate Expenses Policy, as amended from time to time. Candidates must book their own travel, using the most economical option, and provide original hard copy receipts for reimbursement.

Please note, you should only launch your application from within the UK. If you are based overseas, you should wait until you visit the UK to launch an application. Applying from outside the UK will impact on our ability to progress your application. You should not discuss your application, other than with your partner or a close family member.

Right to close applications early:

Please be aware that we reserve the right to close applications once a certain number have been received. Please submit your application as soon as possible to avoid missing out. If you have a disability (as defined under the Equality Act 2010) and need additional time to complete your application. Then, contact us via the email provided as soon as possible, using the subject

line Reasonable Adjustments Extension and briefly outline the support you require.

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo an enhanced (or equivalent) criminal record check.

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is [developed vetting \(opens in a new window\)](#).

[See our vetting charter \(opens in a new window\)](#).

People working with government assets must complete [baseline personnel security standard \(opens in new window\)](#) checks.

Medical

Successful candidates will be expected to have a medical.

Nationality requirements

Open to UK nationals only.

Working for the Civil Service

The [Civil Service Code \(opens in a new window\)](#) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's [recruitment principles \(opens in a new window\)](#).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the [Civil Service People Plan \(opens in a new window\)](#) and the [Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy \(opens in a new window\)](#).

Apply and further information

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : careers@recruitment.org.uk

Email : careers@recruitment.org.uk

Recruitment team

Email : careers@recruitment.org.uk

